

Geographically, India played an indirect role in the early phases of the war as no warfare was directed against the subcontinent until 1942. Instead, men and materiel were shipped from India to support the British effort in other war zones. The railways were stripped of a vast majority of their equipment and were left with the bare minimum required for reduced civilian service.

More than 26 branch lines were dismantled and around 8 per cent metre-gauge locomotives, 15 per cent metre-gauge wagons, and 4 million sleepers were dispatched to foreign war fronts, particularly the Middle East. Railway workshops were utilized as munition plants. As priorities changed, rail repairs were delayed and the available rolling stock suffered greatly. Since one half of all senior railway positions were designated for British personnel, the conscription of European citizens meant that the railways in India were left to function without a large percentage of experienced employees.

Caught napping

The Japanese invasion of the Southeast Asian sector had begun by 1940 with an attack on French Indochina. The Japanese focus on this war theatre increased after their attack on Pearl Harbor in December 1941. The British Government in India, which had always felt threatened by the possibility of a Russian assault in the north-west region towards their border with Afghanistan, had devoted all its attention to establishing defensive infrastructures, including railway lines, to ensure rapid troop movements in that region.

The eastern front was lamentably lacking in defensive infrastructure or communication systems. Apart from river steamer services and two unmetalled trunk roads, the region had a metre-gauge line through two valleys. India's eastern frontier became the primary launchpad for the counter-offensive against Japan when the Japanese captured Singapore in February, and then Burma in May 1942. In order to maintain command over the north-eastern rail link, the Government took over the Assam Bengal Railway Company (ABR). On 1 January 1942, the Government-owned Eastern Bengal Railway (EBR) merged with the ABR to form the Bengal and Assam Railway (BAR).